

Robert Clay Grubbs
 Dr. Rone Shavers
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A Dreamed Center: The Illusion of Identity in *Erasure*

Percival Everett's *Erasure*'s novel-within-a-novel, *My Pafology*, begins with a dream sequence in which the novel's protagonist, Van Go Jenkins, murders his own mother with a kitchen knife. The scene opens with his mother calling both him and his younger sister, "human slough," to which Van Go responds by grabbing a kitchen knife and "put[ting] the knife in her stomach and pull[ing] it out red," (Everett, 65). The shock of his own actions sends Van Go into a frenzy as he realizes he "don't know what goin on. So, I stab Mama again," (65). As he drives the knife into his mother, he claims that he's stabbing her "cause I love her," and also because "I hate her," but finally, because "I ain't got no daddy," (65). He then leaves her to die on the floor, leaves the house, and looks to the sky to "try to see Jesus," but there's nothing there (65). After his dreamed self shrugs this off and wonders "which one of [his] fo' babies [he's] gone go see," Van Go wakes up, ending this dream, a story-within-a-novel-within-a-novel (65).

This doubly framed narrative that occurs before any of the events of *My Pafology* produces a very odd effect. Lucien Dällenbach, when describing the functionality of an embedded narrative, or a *mise-en-abyme*, considers its qualities as a narrative instance to be an "intertextual résumé or quotation of the content of a work," (55). The embedded narrative internally captures and summarizes the total content of the *embedding* narrative, which also includes the embedded, leading to a sort of hole in the narrative that "gives rise to internal repetition," (Dällenbach, 55). The embedding narrative of the dream, *My Pafology*, works as a reflection of its own embedding narrative, where Van Go's experience acts as an internal mirror

for the central character of *Erasure*, Thelonious “Monk” Ellison. This novel that Monk writes under the pseudonym Stagg R. Leigh, being positioned in the middle of *Erasure*, works as a *retro-prospective mise-en-abyme* that provides “a fulcrum between the ‘already’ and the ‘not yet’,” (Dällenbach, 67). *My Pafology* not only summarizes what has occurred already, but by acting as a centered fulcrum, also prophesizes the rest of *Erasure*. This prophetic function is fairly well illustrated by the literal equivalences in both novel’s endings, where Van Go and Monk both look towards cameras pointed at them and proclaim, “Look at me, I on TV,” and “Egads, I’m on television,” respectively (Everett, 131,265). But *My Pafology*’s embedded dream, its opening, is an embedding missing from its mirrored counterpart, complicating the retro-prospection of the reflection.

An initial *mise-en-abyme* that happens before the rest of a text is one that acts entirely as a prophecy, since the internal reflection summarizes the whole work before it occurs. Dällenbach describes this prospective kind of *mise-en-abyme* as a programmatic structure that “provides a ‘double’ for the fiction in order to ‘overtake’ it and to leave it with only a past for its future,” (61). This violent dream sequence then works as a prospective reflection of the whole of *My Pafology*, which in turn reflects the entirety of *Erasure* in a retro-prospective manner. With this dream being a metaphorical transposition of the narrative’s totality, Dällenbach considers its function similar to “figures created by what Freudian psychoanalysis calls the ‘primary processes’,” that codify these processes “rather like the ‘dreamwork’,” (57). This literal dream, which works as a symbolic reflection of the total narrative’s structure, begs to be read in relation to the rest of the text as an actual dreamwork.

In fact, Irene Rose De Lilly applies Freud’s *Interpretation of Dreams* to tease out the relation between Van Go’s dream’s manifest content and its latent meaning. She lists five core

elements of the dream that are particularly noteworthy, “human slough, the knife, the color red, the kitchen, and Jesus,” (3). The importance of human slough to De Lilly is the fact that “Van Go’s mother equates her son’s potential in life to that of dead skin,” which is what triggers Van Go’s violent reaction (3). The knife, notably phallic, is what brings out the color red, in which De Lilly mentions many symbolic connections, the most relevant here being that of castration (3). The kitchen, and scene of violence, is then described as “the womb of the home,” which Van Go exits, leading him to look to the sky “in a desperate attempt to find some sort of redemption or guidance,” (De Lilly, 4). While De Lilly is interested in this symbolic analysis to reach Everett’s own psyche and presence within the novel, the decodification of primary processes is still a useful means to unpack this mirror of *Erasure*’s totality.

De Lilly notes that “buried within these dreams and memories are Monk’s, or presumably Everett’s deep frustrations regarding race and publication,” (4). Monk’s character, who writes to the reader in the form of a journal, certainly mirrors Everett’s position as a writer, and it becomes easy to conflate the two of them; both are notably erudite “writers of ‘experimental fiction’” who struggle “in their writing careers because of the publishing industry’s notion of a universal blackness,” (Porter, 107). Regarding Monk specifically, the second page of the novel makes this point fairly clearly with a quoted response from a reviewer of Monk’s work:

The novel is finely crafted, with fully developed characters, rich language and subtle play with plot, but one is lost to understand what this reworking of Aeschylus’ The Persians has to do with the African American experience, (2).

Monk’s work suffers under the demands of the industry, and despite his stance that he doesn’t “believe in race,” he also acknowledges that there will be people who “try to stop me because

they do believe in race, because of my brown skin,” (2). The industry, which believes in “a notion of universal, essentializing blackness,” that’s perpetuated by white expectations could potentially, in regards to Van Go’s dream, be posited as his mother who calls him human slough (Porter, 107). This phrase’s equivalence to the potential of dead skin, or a subject made passive through an essentialized identity related to skin, seems to be an apt symbol for Monk’s position within the narrative. The industry, which is capable of giving life to and mothering Monk’s work, looks down on him, leading to a violent reaction.

In fact, directly before Monk sits down to write *My Pafology*, his most recent novel, *The Second Failure*, is turned down by three editors, one of which outright says that the “market won’t support this kind of thing,” (61). Monk, at this point dealing with his sister’s death and his mother’s failing memory on top of the expectations of industry begins to collapse under the weight of this stress:

The pain started in my feet and coursed through my legs, up my spine and into my brain and I remembered passages of *Native Son* and *The Color Purple* and *Amos and Andy* and my hands began to shake, the world opening up around me, tree roots trembling on the ground outside, (61).

His reaction to this rejection and the essentialism projected onto his identity as an artist pushes him to write *My Pafology*, “a book on which I knew I could never put my name,” (62). With the novel itself being a satire that he sends out as an “expression of [his] being sick of it,” it falls into place as a reactive device, the knife Van Go takes up arms against his mother, (132). And so, Monk, as Leigh, writes the first paragraph of *My Pafology*, the retro-prospective mise-en-abyme of his own story, with his own expectations of his future giving form to the symbolism.

By that logic, *My Pafology* could be considered a phallic object through its equivalency to the knife. The phallus is thought of by Lacan as a “symbol” or capture “of the body’s libido” directed “toward the object,” (696). It becomes the object in which the subject believes it can actualize its own unconscious desire, and in the case of Monk, he at first believes this phallus is capable of actualizing his frustrations towards the racial expectations of the publishing industry. But Monk’s desire isn’t necessarily a singular object, since the six-hundred thousand dollars offered for *My Pafology* begins to motivate him to take on the guise of his pseudonym, Leigh.

“This is really fucked up, you know that.”

“You don’t want the deal.”

“Of course I want the deal,” I said, “Just tell them that Stagg Leigh is painfully, pathologically shy and that he’ll communicate with them through you,” (136).

Between the financial weight of his mother’s need for elderly care and the discriminatory lack of support from publishers, Monk sees this as a necessary opportunity. His initial frustrations expressed in the satire of *My Pafology* are subverted by other needs when the work is accepted not as parody, but as “true to life,” (136). The knife is pulled on the mother, but the reasoning is jumbled during the act. Like Van Go’s feelings toward his mother, Monk hates the industry, and as Leigh, he loves the industry.

The retro-prospective function of the dream is now called into question; Van Go’s mother bleeds out on the floor, yet in *Erasure*’s case, the industry holds strong, and subverts Monk’s reactive phallus. Dällenbach notes that the prophetic aspect of a mise-en-abyme is capable of being subverted, which allows it to “provoke tension,” (61). In a reading of Tieck’s *Der Zauberschloss*, he describes its subversion of the story’s initial prophecy as “an ironic happy

ending, having been misled by the false prophecy of the inserted narrative,” (62). The dream’s symbolism written by Monk in his expectations of the industry’s reaction is inverted, as the actual irony of *My Pafology* is negated by a doubly ironic incident. The industry then takes claim of the phallus, which in effect, through his financial needs, symbolically castrates Monk, bringing truth to the castrating connotation of the color red, while flipping the dream’s resolution.

To Lacan, the idea of castration, or the Freudian “castration complex,” is brought forth by “the formulation of desire” towards an object separate from oneself, something the subject lacks. This projection of the subject’s needs, then searches in that object for what is “usually forbidden,” and in fact “doesn’t exist,” (Lacan, 694-695). For the neurotic, desire then “institutes the dominance” of the chosen object, and transforms the object’s inability to provide gratification, its lack, into the object’s demands of the subject (Lacan, 698). The neurotic in this instance is left castrated, and Monk, in searching for an effective phallic object to reject the industry’s demands on his identity, or the “part that is missing in the desired image,” is subverted (Lacan, 697). The phallus is taken by the industry, as Monk’s reaction directly corresponds to the object’s demands, leaving him castrated. Nearing the end of the novel, shortly before Monk steps onto the televised stage as Stagg R. Leigh, he writes:

So I had managed to take myself, the writer, reconfigure myself,
then disintegrate myself, leaving two bodies of work, two bodies,
no boundaries yet walls everywhere. I had caught myself standing
naked in front of the mirror and discovered that I had nothing to
hide and that lack was exactly what forced me to turn away.
Somehow I had whacked off my own

willy, (257).

His lack, or his desire, which drove him to overwrite his own identity, to place Leigh's name on *My Pafology* instead of his own, has forced him to turn away from himself, to become the image of what his desire demands from him. Instead, Leigh faces the mirror, the industry and its consumers; he embodies the mirror image of the object's demands, the castrating force, and Monk's identity is left disintegrated.

Monk's identity is made invisible not only through the public's reaction to reading *My Pafology*, but also by the authorial function of mise-en-abyme; because he chose to place Leigh's name on the cover, Monk's fate was resigned to the authorship of another person. Dällenbach describes the "nature of a text" as the simultaneous exclusion of "its empirical producer," and the inclusion, "in place of this exiled subject, a subject who has no existence beyond the enunciation s/he subtends, who is anonymous despite the name given on the title page," (76). Then, the name on the title page, which is the only direct sign for this illusory author who "can have no face," takes the role of this missing face (76). As Monk moves onto the television stage at the end of the novel, he looks into a mirror held up by a child that he thinks is "perhaps [him] as a boy," only to realize that the face in the mirror isn't his, but "the face of Stagg Leigh," (264). Monk holds up the mirror; he writes *My Pafology*, the mirror of his own story, and therefore writes the future into being. But by writing himself out for Leigh, he loses his face entirely, allowing Leigh to dominate his fate. *Erasure* then becomes an inversion of the dream's failed prophecy; the kitchen, the womb in which the mother subverts Monk's phallic reaction, forces Monk to father Leigh, who walks out outside, on stage, instead of the originally prophesied Monk.

By writing to an audience that subverts Monk's intentions, and by placing Leigh's name on the cover, Monk's identity is erased. But Monk's metamorphosing castration is then also a

reflection of the excluded, implied author, since Everett allows for Monk to write in his stead.

The book itself opens, without immediately naming its writer, but with the invisible author claiming, “My journal is a private affair,” and without another name given, this self-referentiality is initially drawn to the name on the cover, the one responsible for the book, (Everett, 1).

Immediately following this, the author considers his coming death, which he “cannot know the time of,” only to then proclaim, “My name is Thelonious Ellison. And I am a writer of fiction,” (1). Immediately, this faceless version of Everett is overwritten; this identity’s death is brought about by a fictional writer, who claims “to be something else,” other than a writer, again erasing an established identity (1). He overwrites himself as “a son, a brother, a fisherman, an art-lover, a woodworker,” all of which are evidenced through smaller asides scattered throughout the book (1). Finally, he directly speaks to the reader with a clear imperative, “Call me Monk,” concluding this iterative metamorphosis from implied author to established character (1). Everett’s position in the text is seemingly replaced through Monk’s so-called ‘private’ journal, which is brought to the public, destroying the original writer’s identity in much the same way Leigh’s identity erases Monk’s.

But Monk’s pre-castrated identity, in and of itself, is more complex than just this self-established character. His name, being a hybrid of jazz pianist Thelonious Monk and author Ralph Ellison, constructs an identity directly signifying on an African-American arts heritage. Henry Louis Gates defines the concept of signifying as “a theory of reading that arises from Afro-American culture,” which is driven by an ironic subversion of the sign’s signified counterpart, (*Figures in Black* 235-236). The subversive effect of signifying “is a mode of discourse at the heart of African-American literary and musical traditions which creatively engage previous discourse,” allowing for an interaction between current and previous texts that

are a part of this tradition (Butler, 7). This cultural mode of signifying is often represented by the idea of the “Signifying Monkey,” who embodies this “Signifier” that “wreaks havoc upon the Signified,” through the allusion to an artistic heritage (Gates, *Figures in Black* 238). Monk’s name could also then be signifying on the larger figure of the Signifying Monkey, given that his name already doubly acts as this literary device, which would then allow *Erasure* to seemingly toy with the role of this tradition itself.

Then, by allowing Monk, a signification of the device of signifying itself, to step in for Everett, the mise-en-abyme of Everett’s writing process expands to incorporate the whole of the signifying cultural corpus. The ways in which an authorial figure can be mirrored through a mise-en-abyme is by giving the substitute “an appropriate profession or occupation,” or “a symbolic name,” or, even more specifically “a surname which evokes the one on the title page,” (Dällenbach, 76). Monk embodies all three of these functions; the profession mirrors Everett, the surname refers back not to the title page of *Erasure*, but instead signifies on and mirrors Ellison’s works, as well as symbolically mirroring the process of signifying itself, flaunting the text’s self-awareness of its literary history and lineage. Monk’s identity is not only built upon the traits he himself has explicitly written for the reader, but also the Signifying corpus of the Monkey. *Erasure*’s self-reflection is then afforded the ability to link “the past and the present,” to unite this array of books and reactivate them, all at once, (Dällenbach, 77). This self-referential use of signifying then maps onto the self-referential structure of mise-en-abyme. It generates an internally repetitive mise-en-abyme of African-American literary history, where the narrative signifies on itself, as one iteration in this literary chain.

The novel as a whole also structures itself as a reflection of a particular exchange in African-American literary history. Monk’s writing of *My Pafology* works to reflect the

ideological disagreements between Ralph Ellison and Richard Wright. With Monk's name signifying on Ellison, and the writing of *My Pafology* being a "transparent updating of Richard Wright's *Native Son*, the foundational text in the construction of the category "African-American novel," the plot of the narrative seems to signify directly onto Ellison's critiques of Wright's work (Russett, 364). Ellison has notably revised, and signified on Wright's work in the past (Gates, *Figures in Black* 242). Monk's and potentially Everett's, rewriting of *Native Son*, mirrors Ellison's critiques of Wright's work, and refusal to "be constrained by any narrow prescriptions imposed on him as a "black" writer," (Butler, 8). Through signifying on this past exchange and critique, *Erasure* constructs a self-aware "dialectical reading of 'the African-American novel,'" where these opposing views within African-American literary history are both simultaneously parodied and honored (Russett, 365).

Given this fact, not only Wright's work, but also Ellison's, is being signified on and revised by Everett in *Erasure*. Monk's castration in and of itself signifies on the imagined castration of Ellison's *Invisible Man*. According to Butler, signifying can either be "honorific," deepening and broadening the "previous work in an affirmative manner," or "ironic," where "the meaning of an earlier work is reversed or undercut," (7). And Butler notes that in the case of *Erasure*, it "artfully signifies on Ellison's *Invisible Man* in both ways," (7). As Monk sees Stagg's face in his reflection at the end of the novel, Stagg asks Monk a question directly alluding to the question Ellison's hero in *The Invisible Man* is asked after being castrated, "How does it feel to be free of one's illusions?" (264). In response, Monk says to no one, "I know those lines," and following suit with the answer given in *The Invisible Man*, he says, "The answer is *Painful and empty*," (265). Though, following this imagined castration, rather than an optimistic hope for "a reconstituted America of 'infinite possibilities'" that comes about in *The Invisible*

Man, Erasure's Ellisonian mirror, Monk, *is* castrated by the "cheap fantasies of daytime television," and left "imprisoned by the fear that money and celebrity might erase him," (Butler, 9). To *Erasure*, the industry of literary production, led by a commercialized essentialism of any culture other than whiteness, leaves Ellison's hope for a rejection of these notions contained and confined within the public's stereotype of African-American literature defined by Wright.

Then, since Monk signifies on signifying, allowing this history to stand in as the original author of *My Pafology*, this mise-en-abyme positions itself to be read as a generalized frustration of black authorship within the American literary industry. Its centered dream, with its subverted phallus, and the birth of Leigh, implies a self-fathering relationship within the industry, where an author tries to reject the image imposed on them, only to reinforce it, birthing more "iterations of a pernicious stereotype," (Russett, 365). The industry demands "endless reiterations of the same image," snuffing out the capability for subversion, forcing African-American authors to father the same stereotype over and over again, (Yost, 1326). Van Go's frustrations about his absent father in this dream are then frustrations with this identity-less cycle. Van Go's father is Monk, his previous iteration and embedding mirror, who turns back to reflect the historical process of signifying, which in and of itself forms a similarly reflecting, iterative "hall of mirrors," (Gates, *Signifying Monkey* 64). *Erasure* proposes that each attempt to revise, or honor a former iteration of African-American literature is castrated by industry; it's forced into hegemonic self-perpetuation of stereotypes within this industrially overwritten mirror hall.

But, this claim towards a larger, more general African-American literary experience confines these literary works within the same kind of box as the described limitations of industry. To utilize Monk as a means to signify on signifying is to place the entire, non-universal experience of the artists engaged with this tradition in a singular body, overwriting them twice

over. In effect, it does exactly what Monk hates: placing the work of African-American theorists and writers in the same section, regardless of interest or subject.

I found a section called African American Studies and there, arranged alphabetically and neatly, read *undisturbed*, were four of my books including my *Persians* of which the only thing ostensibly African American was my jacket photograph. I quickly became irate, my pulse speeding up, my brow furrowing (28).

Erasure then, in a way, cuts to the chase of this matter, and parodies itself through this kind of intertextual overwriting before industry has the time to try and birth another Leigh out of it. The actual book, upon reaching the market, was even offered a reissuing “as the inaugural work in a new series of African-American fiction,” to which Everett declined (Russett, 364). By allowing Monk to overwrite himself, Everett ironically erases his own identity in much the same way that Leigh and the industry that adopts him, overwrites Monk. Rather than failing to escape the trap of essentialization, *Erasure* satirizes this trap through its self-awareness as an object in an iterative, castrating industry. It plays the role of the reflective *My Pafology* willingly, allowing this irony to remain hidden, erased.

The pre-subverted dream is then reflective of *Erasure*’s irony. The supposed goal of black authorship is stripped of its identity by an industry through the dream’s subversion, but the identity of this “black authorship” is itself a joke, already an erasure. The phallus, or text, becomes a triply ironic sleight-of-hand, and the actual identity of the text and author is snuck-in in a present, yet unrecoverable form. Using Monk to signify signifying as a whole then takes on a more honorific function, where the commercialized identity of those amongst this literary lineage is parodied before *Erasure*’s commercialization as another stereotypical iteration.

Instead, the meaning of this signifying process is kept hidden and indeterminate to the essentializing industry.

Similarly, Everett's identity as an African-American author within the book, inevitably essentialized and interrogated in regard to his beliefs and frustrations with industry, remains at a distance through his parodic mirroring. His position as author is already overwritten by the *mise-en-abyme* that "can only put forward a fiction or metaphor" of an originating reality that's "already out of reach, or already duplicated," (Dällenbach, 101). Despite Monk's seeming relation to Everett through the similarities in their occupation and difficulties, Monk is only one illusion in an ever-extending hall of stereotyped mirrors. By knowing exactly what the industry wants from him, as an object of desire, Everett castrates in retaliation. The dream, by failing as a prophecy in fiction, succeeds in actuality. The erased, mirrored identity of the author steps out of the kitchen and looks to the sky to try and see Jesus, his lord and father, a point of origin. But there is none, and the embedded narrative ends, reflecting one of many possible identities.

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